

Blood and Silk

A Starter Adventure for Fate's Edge

An Introduction to Exile, Redemption, and Second Chances

Adventure Type: Village Defense

Designed for 4-6 players, Rookie characters (0-40 XP)

Game Master's Guide Included

Featuring Pre-generated Characters
Simple Timer Management
Asset Building Through Heroism
Mutual Connections and Bonds

1 Introduction

1.1 Welcome to Acasia

Welcome to Fate's Edge, where every choice carries weight and every action has consequences. This starter adventure, "Blood and Silk," is designed to introduce new players to the core mechanics of the game while telling a story about redemption, community, and the power of second chances.

In the broken marches of Acasia, where law is a suggestion and coin speaks louder than crowns, a group of exiles finds themselves in a small farming village called Millhaven. What starts as a simple misunderstanding quickly escalates into a fight for survival as the village faces threats from all sides.

1.1.1 The Broken Marches

Acasia is not like the green and orderly lands of Viterra or the marble-shadowed courts of Ektoria. It is a place where the Empire's last breath still hangs in the mist, where the old Imperial roads lead nowhere but remember every footstep that marched them. The locals speak of the Curse in whispers – not a monster or a plague, but a slow rot of broken promises and unpaid tolls. A bridge that loops back to the same shore. A milestone that points north at dawn and south by dusk. A bell that tolls for no funeral.

The villagers of Millhaven have learned to live with the Curse. They pour no ninth cup at their feasts. They never sign a contract on a bridge. They leave offerings of salt at every crossroads, just in case the Hollow is listening. They do not speak of the Empire that left them, but they walk its roads every day, and the roads remember.

This is the land you wander now. The road does not forgive. It reschedules.

1.1.2 The Weight of Exile

Your characters are not heroes – not yet. You are exiles, wanderers, people who made choices in Silkstrand that closed doors behind you. Perhaps you crossed a powerful merchant. Perhaps you refused to look away when corruption wore silk robes. Perhaps you simply failed, and failure in a city of ledgers is a debt that compounds.

*If your group played the prequel adventure **The Velvet War of Silkstrand**, you already know the cost of that failure. You carry the memory of Old Kes and the Silk Coin. If you are new to the saga, know only this: Silkstrand took everything from you. Millhaven might give something back.*

Whatever the reason, you find yourselves on the broken roads of Acasia, carrying nothing but your skills, your grudges, and each other. Millhaven is not your home, but it could be. If you can defend it, if you can prove that exiles can still build something worth keeping, you might finally stop running.

The Hollow Listens

In Acasia, the ninth step on any stair is missing. The ninth cup at any table is never poured. The ninth word in any bargain is never spoken. The wise stop at eight and let the silence answer.

If you break these customs – if you step where no step exists, if you pour the cup that should

remain empty – the Hollow may notice you. The Hollow is not a god. It is the interest on every broken promise ever made in this land. It does not hate. It remembers.

In this adventure, whenever a player character knowingly breaks an Acasian custom (pours a ninth cup, takes a ninth step, speaks a ninth name), the GM gains 1 Story Beat to spend on a supernatural complication. The Hollow is patient, but it is always counting.

1.2 Adventure Overview

Adventure Hook: The PCs are exiles from Silkstrand – a cosmopolitan port city where they made choices that cost them their place in society. Now they wander the broken roads of Acasia, trying to survive and perhaps find a place where they belong.

Setting: Millhaven, a small farming village in the Acasian marches, threatened by bandits and political machinations. The village sits in a valley where the old Imperial road forks, and the locals say the fork is where the Curse began.

Themes: Redemption, community, second chances, the weight of exile, and the power of belonging. In Acasia, belonging is not a right. It is earned in sweat and blood.

Tone: Gritty but hopeful. Violence has consequences, but heroism can earn respect and a place to call home. The mist holds fear, but it also hides the road ahead.

Recommended Character Tier: Rookie (0-40 XP) – perfect for new players.

Estimated Play Time: 2-3 sessions

1.3 Connections to the Wider World

Blood and Silk is the first chapter in a saga that follows the exiles from Silkstrand as they carve a place for themselves in the broken world of Fate's Edge. The complete arc includes the prequel *The Velvet War of Silkstrand* and two sequels.

- **The Velvet War of Silkstrand (Prequel):** The fall of the Silk Coin, a principled thieves' guild. The player characters die so that the exiles may escape. Their Legacy Tokens carry into this adventure.
- **This Adventure (Blood and Silk):** The exiles defend Millhaven and earn their first foothold. They learn the customs of Acasia, face the Ursillo Gang, and discover that the Curse is more than superstition.
- **Beyond Millhaven (Sequel):** The exiles travel to the Valvano Ford, where a Vilikari merchant offers honest work escorting grain through contested territory. They encounter the Ykrul wolf-banners and learn that debts on the steppe are paid in stories.
- **The Bronze Gate (Third Adventure):** The exiles venture into the mountains to investigate a cursed seal unearthed by smugglers. They face Prefect Marcellus and learn that some secrets are better left buried.

Rumours and hooks for these future adventures are woven throughout the text, but they should feel like distant thunder – present, but not yet demanding attention.

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2 Session 0: Personalizing Your Exile

Before beginning play, take time to establish the connections between your characters and their shared past in Silkstrand. Discuss these questions with the group:

1. **The Final Straw:** What was the specific event in Silkstrand that forced you all to leave *together*? Was it a scandal you caused, a crime you witnessed, or a choice you refused to make?
2. **Defining Moment:** Look at your Mutual Bonds. Briefly describe the scene where that bond was formed. Was it during the event that exiled you, or on the road afterward?
3. **A Sliver of Hope:** Why is Millhaven different? What about this place makes you want to fight for it, instead of just moving on? Perhaps it reminds you of somewhere you lost, or perhaps the villagers are the first people who have looked at you without disgust.

Example for Kestra and Marcus: Their bond is “We both made choices that cost us our place in Silkstrand.” Perhaps Marcus refused an order to arrest Kestra during the library incident, sacrificing his career to help her escape.

2.1 The City You Left Behind

Silkstrand is a city of bridges and dyewater, where canals carry secrets and every handshake hides a clause. The Matron rules from a palazzo of velvet and iron, and the Archivolt's notaries seal fates with a drop of wax. You were not expelled by decree – you were erased. Your names no longer appear on guild rolls. Your credit is void. Your friends have forgotten your faces, or claim they have.

If you played the prequel, you know who erased you: the Velvet Court, and Madam Serafine's velvet glove. If you are new, let the mystery remain. The road will teach you.

What did you lose? A shop? A reputation? A family? Write it down. That loss is the weight you carry on the road. It is also the coal that will warm you when you finally build something new.

2.2 The Road to Millhaven

You have been walking for weeks. The old Imperial road is cracked and overgrown, its milestones defaced by a dozen failed kingdoms. You have slept in shelter hollows, eaten hardtack soaked in river water, and learned to read the sky for omens. You have told each other stories to keep the silence at bay.

One evening, as the mist rolls down from the hills, you see smoke rising from a cluster of thatched roofs. Millhaven. The road forks here: one branch leads to the village, the other vanishes into a bog where the locals say the Curse is thickest.

You choose the village. You always choose the village.

3 The Story So Far

3.1 The Exiles of Silkstrand

The PCs are not welcome in their former home of Silkstrand. Whether they were involved in a scandal, crossed the wrong person, or simply made choices that powerful people didn't like, they

now find themselves on the outside looking in. With nothing but the clothes on their backs and a burning desire to prove themselves, they have taken to the roads of Acasia.

3.2 Millhaven: A Village in Peril

Millhaven is a small farming community that has managed to stay neutral in the endless conflicts of Acasia. The village sits in a fertile valley surrounded by rolling hills, its thatched-roof cottages clustered around a central square where the weekly market is held. Smoke rises from chimneys in the morning mist, and the sound of children playing echoes through the narrow streets.

But peace is a luxury that is becoming increasingly expensive. The harvest has been poor this year, and bandit raids have left many families struggling. Now the Ursillo Gang has set their sights on the village, demanding “protection money” that would bankrupt the community.

The village is currently under threat from:

- **Bandits:** The Ursillo Gang, a particularly vicious group that demands “protection money”
- **Political Pressure:** Local nobles who want the village to choose sides in their conflicts
- **Economic Hardship:** Poor harvests and bandit raids have left the village struggling
- **The Curse:** The villagers whisper that the bad harvest is not natural – that someone broke a promise on the old Imperial bridge, and the land remembers

3.2.1 The Grey Man of Millhaven

Elder Thorne tells a story to newcomers, though he does not know if it is true. He says that a generation ago, a wandering knight took shelter in Millhaven during a blizzard. The villagers fed him, warmed him, and asked nothing in return. When he left, he carved his name into the stone lintel of the chapel: “*Sir Corin, who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief’s voice.*”

The villagers did not know the name. But when the blizzard cleared, they found a silver coin in every threshold, and the snow had not touched their fields. The knight never returned, but the villagers leave a cup of water on the chapel steps each winter, just in case.

Some say Sir Corin fell at Lence, in Vhasia, during the great sack. Others say he is still walking, unbuckled and unbowed, looking for a place to rest.

3.3 Rumours from the Road (Seeds for the Future)

While the party is in Millhaven, they overhear fragments of news from travellers and merchants. These are not adventure hooks yet – just the quiet hum of a living world.

Rumour Table (d6)

Roll or choose one to mention during downtime:

1. A Vilikari merchant named **Tema** is looking for reliable escorts for a grain caravan heading west. (*Seeds Beyond Millhaven.*)
2. The Ykrul chieftain **Khatun Sarnai** has been seen riding the eastern steppe with her wolf-banners. (*Appears in later adventures.*)

3. A Black Banner mercenary captain called **Rusk** is hiring swords for a “special job” near the Bronze Gate. (*Seeds The Bronze Gate.*)
4. The old ford at Valvano is said to be locked shut – Ykrul, Aeler, and Vilikari all claim it. (*Direct hook for Beyond Millhaven.*)
5. A cursed relic, the *Iron Seal of Varus*, has been dug up somewhere in the mountains. (*Seeds The Bronze Gate.*)
6. The road to the west leads to the **Bronze Gate**, the only pass through the mountains for three weeks’ march – but it is heavily guarded. (*Future location.*)

3.4 The Curse of Acasia (GM Only)

Acasia’s Curse is not a spell. It is a memory. The land remembers the Empire that abandoned it, the promises that were never kept, the roads that were surveyed and then forgotten. The Curse manifests as wrong turns, as milestones that face the wrong direction, as bridges that lead back to where you started. It is not malicious. It is forgetful. And when the Hollow notices a traveler, it is not because the traveler is guilty – it is because the traveler has broken a custom that the land uses to remember itself.

In this adventure, the Curse appears in small ways:

- A milestone near Millhaven has been chiseled seven times. The eighth inscription is still wet, though no one admits to carving it.
- The bridge over the millstream has nine arches, but the locals count only eight. The ninth arch is there, but they will not look at it.
- Elder Thorne pours only eight cups of cider at his table. The ninth cup is an empty chair.

These details are not plot devices. They are atmosphere. The Curse is the taste of mildew on old parchment, the sound of a bell that rings without a clapper, the feeling of being watched from a direction where no one stands. Use it sparingly, but when you use it, let it linger.

4 Pre-Generated Characters

4.1 Character Creation Philosophy

These pre-generated characters are designed to be immediately playable while showcasing different approaches to character building in Fate’s Edge. Each character has:

- Core Attributes and Skills appropriate for a rookie character (0-40 XP)
- A Background Hook that connects them to the setting
- Two Mutual Bonds with other characters (showing the bond-to-boon connection)
- Starting Assets and Boons to demonstrate resource management

[Silk Coin Legacy Tokens] If your group played *The Velvet War of Silkstrand*, each pre-generated character starts with one **Legacy Asset** chosen by the players who sacrificed their Silk Coin heroes. If you did not play the prequel, your characters fled Silkstrand with only what they could carry — but the memory of fallen friends still lingers. Choose one of the following Legacy Assets to represent a parting gift from the Silk Coin:

- *Kestra's Scroll* – A one-use Traveler Rite (any low rite).
- *Marcus's Worn Sword* – Ignores one *Compromised* tag per session.
- *Sariel's Lockpick Set* – +1 die to open any lock that a Silk Coin member once touched.
- *Elena's Medicine Stash* – +1 die to a single Medicine roll (one use).
- *Thane's Toolkit* – Repair one *Compromised* item without a roll (once per arc).
- *Lyra's Diplomatic Papers* – A forged letter of introduction to a Vilikari lord (one use).
- *Finn's Fox Companion* – A Cap 1 follower that can sniff out danger (once per session).
- *Zara's Ledger* – +1 die to Streetwise in Silkstrand.

Place a checkmark next to the token your character carries. The road remembers.

4.2 Glossary of Key Terms

Before diving into the characters, here are brief definitions of key terms you will encounter:

- **Bonds:** Mutual connections between characters that generate Boons when you help each other. Each bond represents a specific shared experience or debt.
- **Boons:** Narrative tokens earned primarily by failing rolls with meaningful consequences. Spend them to re-roll dice, activate Assets, or convert to XP.
- **XP (Experience Points):** Currency earned at the end of sessions to improve your character's Attributes, Skills, or acquire Assets and Talents.
- **SB (Story Beats):** Narrative fuel generated by rolling 1s on dice. The GM spends SB to add complications and twists to the story.

Kestra “The Scholar” - Arcanist

Background: Once a promising student at Silkstrand's Academy of Arts, Kestra was expelled after an experimental ritual went wrong, destroying part of the library. Now she seeks to prove that her knowledge can be used for good.

Attributes: Wits 3, Spirit 2

Skills: Arcana 2, Lore 2, Insight 1

Mutual Bonds:

- With Marcus: “We both made choices that cost us our place in Silkstrand”
- With Sariel: “She saved me from Ursillo bandits once, I owe her”

Starting Resources:

- 3 Boons
- Minor Asset: Scholar's Satchel (contains books, reagents, and a small telescope)
- Talent: Lorekeeper (Once per session, recall obscure history without rolling)

Marcus "The Blade" - Warrior

Background: A former city guard who was discharged after he refused to look the other way while corrupt officials shook down merchants. Now he makes his living as a sellsword, but his heart still yearns for justice.

Attributes: Body 3, Spirit 2

Skills: Melee 3, Athletics 2, Command 1

Mutual Bonds:

- With Kestra: "We both made choices that cost us our place in Silkstrand"
- With Elena: "We fought side by side against Ursillo raiders"

Starting Resources:

- 2 Boons
- Minor Asset: Trusted Blade (a well-maintained sword that never fails)
- Talent: Battle Instincts (Once per scene, re-roll a failed defence roll)

Sariel "The Shadow" - Scout

Background: A former member of Silkstrand's Thieves' Guild who grew tired of the constant violence and backstabbing. She left the guild but still uses her skills to survive on the road.

Attributes: Wits 3, Body 2

Skills: Stealth 2, Survival 2, Subterfuge 1

Mutual Bonds:

- With Kestra: "She saved me from Ursillo bandits once, I owe her"
- With Elena: "We both know what it's like to be an outcast"

Starting Resources:

- 4 Boons
- Minor Asset: Shadow's Cloak (grants advantage on stealth rolls in dim light)
- Talent: Silver Tongue (Gain +1 die when persuading or deceiving through speech)

Elena "The Healer" - Apothecary

Background: A former apothecary who was accused of practicing forbidden arts after she tried to save a patient with experimental treatments. Now she travels the roads, helping those who have nowhere else to turn.

Attributes: Spirit 3, Wits 2

Skills: Medicine 2, Survival 1, Insight 2

Mutual Bonds:

- With Marcus: "We fought side by side against Ursillo raiders"

- With Sariel: “We both know what it’s like to be an outcast”

Starting Resources:

- 3 Boons
- Minor Asset: Healer’s Kit (contains bandages, herbs, and basic medical supplies)
- Talent: Iron Stomach (Immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food)

Thane “The Artisan” - Craftsman

Background: A skilled blacksmith and engineer who was framed for sabotage by a rival guild in Silkstrand. His workshop was destroyed, and he was forced to flee with only his tools and his knowledge.

Attributes: Body 2, Wits 3

Skills: Craft 2, Engineering 2, Survival 1

Mutual Bonds:

- With Kestra: “We both lost our places of learning in Silkstrand”
- With Marcus: “He helped me escape when the guild sent enforcers”

Starting Resources:

- 2 Boons
- Minor Asset: Artisan’s Tools (hammer, tongs, and a small forge kit)
- Talent: Exceptional Coordination (One follower provides +4 assist dice)

Note on Followers: A “follower” is an NPC companion who assists you regularly. Followers have a Cap rating (1-3) that determines how many dice they contribute when helping. Thane’s talent makes a single follower exceptionally effective.

Lyra “The Diplomat” - Courtier

Background: A former court scribe who discovered too much about her lord’s dark dealings. She fled Silkstrand with secret documents that could bring down several noble houses, but she is too principled to use them for personal gain.

Attributes: Presence 3, Wits 2

Skills: Diplomacy 2, Sway 2, Lore 1

Mutual Bonds:

- With Sariel: “We both know how to move through high society unnoticed”
- With Elena: “She helped me when I was injured fleeing Silkstrand”

Starting Resources:

- 3 Boons
- Minor Asset: Diplomatic Papers (official-looking documents that grant minor authority)

- Talent: Backlash Soothing (Reduce magical backlash by 1 SB)

Finn “The Beastmaster” - Ranger

Background: A former royal forester who was dismissed after he refused to help poachers kill a rare white stag that was sacred to the local spirits. He now travels with a loyal wolf companion and a deep respect for nature.

Attributes: Body 2, Spirit 3

Skills: Survival 2, Beastcraft 2, Archery 1

Mutual Bonds:

- With Thane: “We both lost our livelihoods to corruption”
- With Marcus: “He respects my commitment to protecting the innocent”

Starting Resources:

- 2 Boons
- Minor Asset: Wolf Companion (Cap 2 follower with tracking and combat abilities)
- Talent: Beast-Tongue (Communicate with and influence animals)

Zara “The Merchant” - Trader

Background: A clever trader who was run out of Silkstrand after she exposed a smuggling ring that included several city officials. She escaped with her life but lost her business and most of her wealth.

Attributes: Presence 2, Wits 3

Skills: Commerce 2, Subterfuge 2, Insight 1

Mutual Bonds:

- With Lyra: “We both uncovered corruption in Silkstrand’s elite”
- With Sariel: “We worked together to gather evidence against the smugglers”

Starting Resources:

- 4 Boons
- Minor Asset: Merchant’s Network (contacts in various towns and cities)
- Talent: Resourceful (Once per session, find useful items or information without rolling)

5 Core Mechanics Quick Reference

5.1 Attributes and Skills

Characters in Fate’s Edge have four Attributes (Body, Wits, Spirit, Presence) and a variety of Skills that represent specialized training.

Attributes (rated 1-5):

- **Body:** Strength, agility, endurance, and physical prowess
- **Wits:** Perception, quick thinking, memory, and intellect
- **Spirit:** Willpower, intuition, empathy, and magical talent
- **Presence:** Charisma, leadership, appearance, and force of personality

Common Skills:

- **Physical:** Melee, Ranged, Athletics, Stealth, Survival
- **Mental:** Arcana, Lore, Insight, Craft, Engineering, Medicine
- **Social:** Command, Sway, Diplomacy, Subterfuge, Commerce, Beastcraft

5.2 Making Rolls

In Fate's Edge, you resolve important actions by rolling dice:

1. **Determine the Approach:** Choose an Attribute + Skill combination
2. **Set Position:** GM sets Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate)
3. **Roll Dice:** Roll a number of d10s equal to Attribute + Skill
4. **Count Results:**
 - Each 6+ = 1 Success
 - Each 1 = 1 Story Beat (SB)
5. **Apply Outcome:** Compare successes to DV (Difficulty Value, default 3)

5.3 Outcome Matrix

The GM sets a Difficulty Value (DV) for each roll. The default DV is 3, but may range from 2 (very easy) to 5+ (nearly impossible).

Result	Criteria	Effect
Clean Success	Successes $\geq$ DV, 0 SB	Intent achieved crisply, no complications
Success & Cost	Successes $\geq$ DV, 1+ SB	Intent achieved, GM spends SB on complications
Partial	$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$	Partial progress, may gain 1 Boon
Miss	Successes = 0	No progress, GM spends SB, gain 2 Boons

Note on “Clean Success”: This term means you met or exceeded the DV with no Story Beats (no 1s rolled). Your character succeeds without any narrative complications.

Note on Rerolls: When you fail a roll, you may reroll failures (not successes) if you have a relevant talent or asset. Otherwise, you accept the outcome.

5.4 Story Beats (SB)

SB are narrative fuel that the GM spends to add complications:

- **1 SB:** Minor pressure (noise, trace, +1 Supply segment)

- **2 SB:** Moderate setback (alarm, lose position, lesser foe)
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble (reinforcements, gear breaks, rail tick)
- **4+ SB:** Major turn (trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts)

6 How to Run Encounter Boxes

Throughout this adventure, you will find **encounter boxes** like the ones below. These are designed to be run as follows:

6.1 Reading an Encounter Box

Each encounter box contains:

- **Approach:** The recommended Attribute + Skill combination for the roll
- **Position:** The starting Position (Controlled/Risky/Desperate)
- **DV:** The Difficulty Value needed for success
- **Outcome descriptions:** What happens at each result level

6.2 Running the Encounter

1. **Set the scene:** Describe the situation to players
2. **Let players choose approach:** They may suggest alternatives to the listed approach
3. **Set Position and DV:** Use the box as a guideline, adjust based on circumstances
4. **Have player(s) roll:** One primary roller, others may assist
5. **Apply outcome:** Use the box descriptions, but adapt to your table's fiction

6.3 Example of Play

GM: "Garrick sneers at you. 'You think you can threaten me in my own camp?' Kestra, what do you do?"

Kestra: "I try to reason with him. Presence + Sway?"

GM: "That works. This is a Controlled position, DV 4. Roll your 4 dice."

Kestra: "I got 3 successes, but two 1s."

GM: "That's a Success & Cost. You convince him to leave, but I am spending those 2 SB. As Garrick's men ride out, one of them snatches a child from the square. You have got a hostage situation now."

6.4 Key Encounters

Social Encounter: Negotiating with Garrick

- **Approach:** Presence + Sway or Command
- **Position:** Controlled

- **DV:** 4
- **Clean Success:** Garrick leaves temporarily, but vows revenge
- **Success & Cost:** Garrick reduces his demand but takes a hostage (GM spends SB)
- **Partial:** Compromise reached with ongoing tension
- **Miss:** Combat starts immediately with Garrick having initiative

Combat Encounter: Fighting Ursillo Bandits

- **Approach:** Body + Melee or Wits + Subterfuge
- **Position:** Controlled (Desperate if outnumbered)
- **DV:** 3-4 depending on bandit type
- **Clean Success:** Bandit is defeated or routed
- **Success & Cost:** Bandit is wounded but still dangerous (GM spends SB)
- **Partial:** Temporary setback, bandit regroupes
- **Miss:** PC takes damage or is outmanoeuvred

Investigation: Learning About Village Troubles

- **Approach:** Wits + Insight or Lore
- **Position:** Standard
- **DV:** 3
- **Clean Success:** Gain valuable information about Ursillo tactics
- **Success & Cost:** Learn something useful but with complications (GM spends SB)
- **Partial:** Learn something useful but incomplete
- **Miss:** Receive misleading information or waste time

7 Campaign Timers

This adventure uses simplified campaign timers to track the overall progress of the story. Timers are visible to players – they represent mounting tension that the characters can feel.

Village Safety Timer	How close the village is to being overrun
Segments	• • • • • 0/6

Ursillo Threat Timer	How much the Ursillo Gang is organizing against the village
Segments	• • • • • • • 0/8

7.1 Timer Advancement

Village Safety Timer :

- PCs fail to protect villagers: +2 segments
- Ursillo successfully intimidate villagers: +1 segment
- PCs successfully protect villagers: -1 segment (minimum 0)

Ursillo Threat Timer :

- Direct confrontation with Ursillo: +2 segments
- Ursillo casualties: +1 segment
- PCs gain information about Ursillo plans: -1 segment
- PCs successfully intimidate Ursillo: -2 segments

7.2 The Hollow's Attention (Secret GM Timer)

In addition to the visible timers, the GM should track a hidden **Hollow Attention [6]** timer. This represents how much the Curse of Acasia has noticed the party. Tick the timer when:

- A character knowingly breaks an Acasian custom (pours a ninth cup, takes a ninth step, speaks a ninth name) – *tick +1*
- The GM spends 2+ SB on a supernatural complication – *tick +1*
- A character swears an oath on a bridge or at a crossroads – *tick +1*
- The party lingers in a place where the Curse is strong (the old Imperial bridge, the bog at the fork) – *tick +1 per scene*

When the timer reaches 4 segments, the Hollow's presence becomes tangible: milestones shift, bells ring without being struck, and villagers avoid certain thresholds. When the timer reaches 6 segments, the Hollow manifests as an Oath-Keeper – a grey figure that appears at the edge of the village and demands a story, a memory, or a name. The party can appease it by offering one of these, or drive it away by succeeding on a group Spirit + Resolve test (DV 4). If they fail, the Hollow takes something – a shadow, a memory, or a promise – and the timer resets to 3.

This timer is not meant to be a primary driver of the adventure, but a lurking reminder that Acasia is not safe. Use it sparingly, but when you use it, let the table feel the weight.

7.3 Session 1 Resolution

At the end of Session 1, the PCs should have:

- Fought or negotiated with the Ursillo Gang

- Learned about the village's troubles
- Made enemies of the Ursillo (Ursillo Threat Timer advances)
- Either protected or endangered the village (Village Safety Timer changes accordingly)
- Possibly attracted the Hollow's attention (if they broke customs)

8 Session 2: The Village Fights Back

8.1 Opening Scene: The Strategic Crossroads

Garrick's retaliation has made it clear the village cannot simply wait to be attacked. Elder Thorne and the PCs must decide on a primary strategy. Present the players with a clear choice that will define the rest of the adventure:

The village elder's study is warm and filled with the scent of old books and wood smoke. Maps and ledgers cover his desk, and the weight of responsibility shows in his tired eyes. "We cannot wait for them to return," he says, his voice heavy with concern. "We must choose our path – do we fortify and hold, or do we take the fight to them?"

Option A: Fortify and Hold The village will focus on building defences: palisades, traps, and a militia.

- **Primary Asset Gained:** *Village Militia*
- **Primary Challenge:** Resource scarcity and maintaining morale during the siege.
- **Session 2 Focus:** Defence-oriented encounters (building traps, training militia, withstanding probing attacks).

Option B: Strike First The village's best chance is to take the fight to the Ursillo, targeting their camp or a key lieutenant.

- **Primary Asset Gained:** *Scouting Reports* (grants a bonus to the final battle)
- **Primary Challenge:** The danger of the expedition and leaving the village lightly defended.
- **Session 2 Focus:** Offensive-oriented encounters (scouting, ambushing supply lines, a raid on a bandit outpost).

Mechanical Impact:

- The chosen strategy sets the **primary tone and encounters** for Session 2.
- The *other* strategy becomes a **secondary timer** that can still be advanced with good rolls, representing limited efforts on that front.
- This choice makes the players feel they are directing the narrative, not just reacting to it.

8.2 Consequences of the Choice

If Fortify and Hold:

- PCs work with villagers to build palisades and traps
- Ursillo make probing attacks to test defences
- Elder Thorne provides tactical guidance

- Tom the Smith helps forge weapons for the militia

If Strike First:

- PCs lead a scouting mission into Ursillo territory
- Opportunity to eliminate key Ursillo lieutenants
- Risk of leaving village undefended during the operation
- Chance to gather intelligence for the final battle

8.3 Key Encounters

Fortify and Hold Path:

1. **Defence Planning:** Helping the villagers organize (Presence + Command or Wits + Tactics)
2. **Construction:** Building fortifications (Body + Athletics or Wits + Craft)
3. **Training:** Preparing the militia (Presence + Command or Body + Melee)
4. **Probing Attack:** Defending against Ursillo scouts (Combat encounter)

Strike First Path:

1. **Scouting Mission:** Learning about Ursillo movements (Wits + Stealth or Survival)
2. **Ambush:** Attacking Ursillo supply lines (Wits + Subterfuge or Body + Melee)
3. **Raid:** Infiltrating a Ursillo outpost (Wits + Stealth or Presence + Command)
4. **Escape:** Returning to the village with intelligence (Body + Athletics or Wits + Survival)

8.4 Asset Building

As the PCs help the village, they begin to earn the trust and respect of the villagers. This is represented by gaining Assets that reflect their growing connection to the community.

Asset Award Triggers:

- Successfully train 5+ villagers: Gain *Village Militia* asset
- Build 3+ defensive structures: Gain *Fortified Village* asset
- Secure outside aid: Gain *Allied Support* asset
- Complete a dangerous scouting mission: Gain *Scouting Reports* asset
- Win over sceptical villagers: Gain *Elder's Trust* asset

Possible Assets:

- **Village Militia:** A group of armed villagers who will follow the PCs into battle
- **Elder's Trust:** The village elder's confidence
- **Safe House:** A place in the village where the PCs can rest and recover
- **Local Knowledge:** Understanding of the area that grants advantages on Survival rolls

Gaining Assets: PCs can gain Assets by:

- Successfully completing important tasks for the village
- Making significant sacrifices for the community
- Building strong relationships with key NPCs

8.5 Session 2 Resolution

At the end of Session 2, the PCs should have:

- Helped organize the village defence or conducted a strike mission
- Gained at least one Asset representing their connection to the community
- Faced increased Ursillo pressure (timers advance)
- Made meaningful choices about how to protect the village
- Possibly faced a manifestation of the Hollow if the hidden timer advanced

9 Session 3: The Final Stand

9.1 Opening Scene: The Ursillo Return

Garrick Ursillo has had enough. He gathers all his forces for one final assault on Millhaven, determined to make an example of the village and anyone who dares to oppose him.

The morning mist hangs heavy over the valley as the sound of approaching horses echoes through the hills. Scouts return with grim news – Garrick has returned with twice the men, and this time they mean to burn the village to the ground. The final battle is upon them.

Elder Thorne stands in the village square, his face grim but resolute. “They come for our homes, our families, our very lives,” he declares to the gathered villagers. “But we will not go quietly into the night. Today, we fight for Millhaven!”

The Final Threat:

- **Overwhelming Numbers:** 20+ Ursillo bandits led by Garrick and his lieutenants
- **Siege Tactics:** Ursillo attempt to cut off supplies and starve the village out
- **Personal Vendetta:** Garrick specifically targets the PCs
- **Destruction Intent:** They plan to burn the village regardless of resistance

9.2 Key Encounters

1. **Final Preparations:** Last-minute preparations for battle (Various skills)
2. **The Battle of Millhaven:** The climactic fight against the Ursillo (Mass combat simplified)
3. **Confronting Garrick:** The final showdown with the gang leader
4. **Aftermath:** Dealing with the consequences of victory (Social encounter)

9.3 Simplified Mass Combat

For the final battle, use this simplified system:

Village Defence Timer (6 segments):

- Represents how well the village holds out against the assault
- Advances when PCs fail rolls or make tactical errors
- Retreats when PCs succeed or make good choices

Ursillo Morale Timer (8 segments):

- Represents how close the Ursillo are to breaking and running
- Advances when PCs deal damage or intimidate enemies
- Retreats when Ursillo succeed in their attacks

Combat Resolution:

- PCs make rolls to lead the defence (Presence + Command)
- PCs make rolls to fight individual enemies (Body + Melee)
- PCs make rolls to protect villagers (Various skills)
- Success advances Ursillo Morale Timer , failure advances Village Defence Timer

Mass Combat Turn

Each round of the battle, the PCs choose one approach for the group. Roll the primary fighter's dice pool; others may assist (max +3 dice total).

Approach Options:

- **Lead the Defence (Presence + Command):** Organise villagers to hold the line. Success: Ursillo Morale +1, Village Defence -1. Failure: Village Defence +1.
- **Fight on the Front Line (Body + Melee):** Engage bandits directly. Success: Ursillo Morale +2, but PCs risk Harm. Failure: Village Defence +1 and a PC takes Harm 1.
- **Protect the Weak (Wits + Insight or Body + Athletics):** Shield villagers from harm. Success: Prevent Village Defence from advancing for one round. Failure: Village Defence +1 and a named NPC is endangered.
- **Harass and Ambush (Wits + Stealth or Subterfuge):** Use tactics to disorient the enemy. Success: Ursillo Morale +1 and the next attack against Garrick gains +1 die. Failure: No effect, but the GM gains 1 SB.

The battle ends when either timer fills. If the Village Defence Timer fills first, the village is overrun (see "The Village Falls" below). If the Ursillo Morale Timer fills first, Garrick's forces break and flee.

9.4 The Confrontation with Garrick

When the PCs finally face Garrick in single combat (or as a group against him and his remaining lieutenants), the encounter should feel personal and climactic.

Garrick Ursillo - Final Boss

Threat Level: Major

Harm: 3

SB Generation: 3-4 SB per round

Description: Garrick is a veteran fighter with scars that tell stories of countless battles. His sword is well-maintained and deadly, and his eyes burn with the fury of a man who has lost everything and has nothing left to lose. A faded brand on his forearm marks him as a deserter from the Vhasian army – a secret he kills to protect.

Motivations: Revenge, proving his dominance, eliminating threats, hiding his past

Abilities:

- *Master Swordsman:* +2 dice to melee attacks
- *Intimidating Presence:* Opponents start Desperate (generates 1 SB)
- *Tactical Awareness:* Can redirect attacks to minions (once per round)
- *Berserker Rage:* When wounded to Harm 2, gains +1 die to all attacks but loses defensive options (cannot Dodge or Disengage)

Weaknesses:

- Overconfident in his abilities – he will not retreat unless his Morale Timer is nearly empty
- Vulnerable to coordinated attacks from multiple opponents
- Becomes reckless when losing, exposing openings
- Secret shame: if a PC discovers his desertion brand and uses it against him in a social roll, he loses his next action (stunned by recognition)

Combat Stats: Body 4, Melee 4, Spirit 3, Wits 2

Garrick's Lieutenants (Minion Swarms)

If the PCs have not eliminated them earlier, Garrick brings two lieutenants: **Voss** (archer) and **Marta** (brute).

Voss (Ranged Support):

- Ranged attacks (DV 3 to hit), Harm 1 per hit
- *Suppressing Fire:* Can force one PC to drop to Desperate Position for their next action

Marta (Shield Bearer):

- Body 3, Melee 3, Heavy Armour (converts Harm 2 to Fatigue 1)
- *Shield Bash:* On a hit, target must test Body+Resolve (DV 3) or be knocked prone

Minion Swarm Rule: Instead of tracking individual Harm, treat the lieutenants as a single Cap 3 obstacle. Each successful PC attack removes one of them from the fight (narrative). Both must be defeated before Garrick can be cornered.

10 Aftermath

10.1 The Village Stands

If the PCs successfully defend the village (Ursillo Morale Timer fills before Village Defence Timer):

- Garrick is captured, killed, or driven off. His gang scatters.
- The villagers hold a victory feast. Elder Thorne offers the PCs a permanent place in Millhaven.
- Each PC gains 2 Boons (the community's gratitude) and a *Village Trust* minor asset (free shelter, +1 die to social rolls in Millhaven).
- The Ursillo Threat Timer resets to 0. The Village Safety Timer resets to 0.
- The Hollow's Attention timer, if advanced, does not reset – the Curse lingers. The villagers warn that Garrick's broken oath (his desertion) may have attracted something worse.

10.2 The Village Falls: A Road to Redemption

If the Village Defence Timer fills before the Ursillo Morale Timer, Millhaven is overrun. But this is not the end – it is a turning point.

Immediate Aftermath:

- The PCs escape with a small group of survivors (including key NPCs like Mira the Baker and Tom the Smith). Elder Thorne is gravely wounded; he may not survive the journey.
- Each player gains a new **Bond of Shared Trauma** with another PC: “We failed together, and we will atone together.”
- The **Refugee Caravan (Minor Asset)** is automatically gained, representing the survivors and their scant resources.
- The Ursillo Threat Timer resets to 0 (they have what they wanted – the village – and are unlikely to pursue immediately). The Village Safety Timer is replaced by a **Refugee Morale [6]** timer.

The Redemption Arc - Choose Your Path: The survivors look to the PCs for leadership. Present the group with a clear choice for their next goal:

1. **Seek Sanctuary in Vhasia:** A duchy in Vhasia to the east might offer protection, but gaining entry will require proving their worth and navigating strict bureaucracy. (Shifts the campaign to a political/intrigue theme. Seeds *Beyond Millhaven*.)
2. **Appeal to the Acasian “Nobility”:** Confront the local rulers whose inaction allowed the Ursillo to thrive. This is dangerous and could see the PCs framed as scapegoats. (Shifts the campaign to a social/judicial theme.)
3. **Become Guerrillas:** Stay in the region, harassing Ursillo supply lines and freeing other villages from the shadows. The Ursillo become a persistent **Hunt Timer [8]** pursuing them. (Shifts the campaign to a military/insurgency theme.)

New Campaign Timers for the Arc:

- **Refugee Morale (6):** Tracks the hope and cohesion of the survivors. Filling it grants a boon (e.g., a new Asset); emptying it causes desertions or a desperate gamble.

- **Ursillo Hunt (8):** Tracks how close the main Ursillo force is to finding the caravan. Advances when the PCs leave obvious traces or when the GM spends SB on pursuit. When full, a major combat encounter occurs.
- **Political Pressure (6):** (If choosing paths 1 or 2) Represents external forces trying to manipulate or eliminate the group.

11 Resource Management

11.1 Boons

Boons are narrative tokens earned primarily by failing rolls with meaningful consequences:

- **Earning Boons:**
 - **Primary:** When you MISS an action with stated stakes and real consequence you gain two; when you PARTIALLY succeed (do not meet the DV but have at least 1 success) you gain one.
 - **Secondary:** Through bond-driven resource generation when aiding allies
 - **GM Discretion:** For exceptional roleplay that advances the story
- **Using Boons:**
 - Re-roll one die after seeing the pool
 - Activate an Off-Screen Asset (1 Boon)
 - Convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once per session)
- **Limits:**
 - Maximum 5 Boons at once
 - Maximum 2 Boons from failures per character per scene
 - End of scene: Reduce held Boons to maximum 2

Significant Action Requirements for Boon Awards:

1. **Procedure followed:** Intent and approach declared; DV set; roll resolved
2. **Stakes stated:** What changes on success; what bites on failure
3. **Consequence lands now:** GM spends or banks SB, applies condition, or advances thread

Design Note: Boons reward leaning into failure. When you fail and the story becomes more interesting, you earn resources to succeed later. This creates a natural cycle of risk and reward.

11.2 Assets

Assets are off-screen resources that extend your influence:

- **Minor (4 XP):** Safehouse, small shop, petty title
- **Standard (8 XP):** Noble title, guild section, spy ring
- **Major (12 XP):** City license, regional network, fortress lease
- **Using Assets:**

- Free effect once per session
- Spend 1 Boon to reshape current scene
- Spend 2 XP to activate outside normal session allowance

11.3 Assets in This Adventure

As you help Millhaven, you can gain these Assets:

Asset	Cost	Effect
Village Militia	Minor (4 XP)	Cap 3 follower - villagers who fight alongside you
Elder's Trust	Minor (4 XP)	+1 die to social rolls in Millhaven
Safe House	Minor (4 XP)	Secure place to rest and recover in village
Local Knowledge	Minor (4 XP)	+1 die to Survival rolls in the area
Village Charter	Standard (8 XP)	Legal protection and village resources

11.4 Spending Resources - Quick Guide

When to Spend Boons:

- ★ Re-roll dice when you really need to succeed
- ★ Activate Assets for crucial advantages
- ★ Convert to XP when you want to improve your character

When to Use Assets:

- Get free help with problems between sessions
- Gain advantage in specific locations
- Solve logistical problems without rolling

Resource Management Tips:

- Do not hoard Boons – use them when they matter most
- Invest in Assets that match your character's strengths
- Remember that Assets require maintenance (roleplay attention)
- Scene limit: 2 Boons from failures per character per scene

12 Character Advancement

12.1 Earning XP

At the end of each session, players earn XP based on their actions:

- **Attendance:** +2 XP (just showing up)
- **Objectives Reached:** +2-4 XP (completing major goals)
- **Discoveries:** +1-2 XP (learning new things)

- **Hard Choices:** +1-2 XP (making difficult moral decisions)
- **Complication Spotlight:** +1-3 XP (embracing narrative twists)
- **Bond/Flag Driven Play:** +1-2 XP (engaging personal storylines)
- **GM Curveball Award:** +0-3 XP (creative problem solving)

12.2 Spending XP

XP can be spent in three ways:

1. **Enhance Self:** Improve Attributes and Skills
 - Attributes: New rating $\times$ 3 XP
 - Skills: New level $\times$ 2 XP
 - Downtime: New rating in days for Attributes, new level in days for Skills
2. **Acquire Assets:** Gain worldly influence
 - Minor: 4 XP, Standard: 8 XP, Major: 12 XP
 - Downtime: 1-3 days for Minor, 1 week for Standard, 1 month for Major
3. **Learn Talents:** Unlock unique abilities
 - Minor Talents: 2-4 XP
 - Major Talents: 5-8 XP
 - Prestige Abilities: 9+ XP (requires Seasoned tier)

Rush Rule: Players may skip downtime by accepting a Haste timer (4 segments). If the timer fills, the new ability or asset carries flaws or narrative complications.

12.3 Sample Advancement Choices

Kestra (The Scholar):

- Raise Arcana from 2 to 3 (6 XP, 3 days downtime)
- Gain the Ritual Master Talent (8 XP)
- Acquire a Library Asset (8 XP, 1 week downtime)

Marcus (The Blade):

- Raise Melee from 3 to 4 (8 XP, 4 days downtime)
- Gain the Silver Tongue Talent (4 XP)
- Acquire a Trusted Mount Asset (4 XP, 3 days downtime)

Sariel (The Shadow):

- Raise Stealth from 2 to 3 (6 XP, 3 days downtime)
- Gain the Beast-Tongue Talent (8 XP)
- Acquire a Spy Network Asset (8 XP, 1 week downtime)

Elena (The Healer):

- Raise Medicine from 2 to 3 (6 XP, 3 days downtime)
- Gain the Healing Light Talent (8 XP)
- Acquire a Healing Sanctuary Asset (8 XP, 1 week downtime)

Thane (The Artisan):

- Raise Craft from 2 to 3 (6 XP, 3 days downtime)
- Gain the Masterwork Creation Talent (10 XP)
- Acquire a Workshop Asset (8 XP, 1 week downtime)

Lyra (The Diplomat):

- Raise Diplomacy from 2 to 3 (6 XP, 3 days downtime)
- Gain the Negotiator's Edge Talent (6 XP)
- Acquire a Noble Contact Asset (8 XP, 1 week downtime)

Finn (The Beastmaster):

- Raise Beastcraft from 2 to 3 (6 XP, 3 days downtime)
- Gain the Pack Leader Talent (8 XP)
- Acquire a Hunting Grounds Asset (8 XP, 1 week downtime)

Zara (The Merchant):

- Raise Commerce from 2 to 3 (6 XP, 3 days downtime)
- Gain the Merchant's Eye Talent (6 XP)
- Acquire a Trading Post Asset (8 XP, 1 week downtime)

13 GM Tips and Advice

13.1 Running This Adventure

Keep It Simple:

- Use the pre-prepared NPCs and scenarios
- Do not overcomplicate the timer mechanics
- Focus on the story and character development

Encourage Player Agency:

- Let players make meaningful choices
- Show how their decisions affect the village
- Reward creative problem-solving

Manage the Pacing:

- Each session should have a clear goal

- Advance timers based on player actions, not arbitrary timing
- Build to climactic moments gradually

The Curse as Atmosphere, Not Punishment: The Hollow and the Curse of Acasia are not gotcha mechanics. Use them to deepen the mood, not to frustrate players. When a player accidentally breaks a custom, describe the uncanny result – a bell that rings without being struck, a shadow that moves independently – and give them a chance to make amends (leave an offering, tell a story). The Hollow is a creditor, not an executioner.

13.2 Using Complications

Complications should enhance the story, not punish players:

- **Good Complications:** Add tension, introduce new elements, create interesting choices
- **Bad Complications:** Are arbitrary, repetitive, or make players feel helpless
- **Best Practice:** Tie complications to the fiction and character choices

SB Spending Guidelines:

- 1 SB: Minor environmental or social pressure
- 2 SB: Moderate tactical disadvantage or setback
- 3 SB: Serious mechanical or narrative consequence
- 4+ SB: Major plot shift or scene change

13.3 Awarding Assets

Assets should feel earned, not given:

- Require meaningful sacrifice or effort
- Tie to specific actions or relationships
- Match the character's concept and the story's needs

14 NPC Gallery

14.1 Key NPCs

Elder Thorne - Village Leader

Role: The wise but weary leader of Millhaven

Motivation: Protect his people at all costs

Personality: Cautious, diplomatic, but capable of great courage when necessary

Relationship to PCs: Initially suspicious, becomes grateful for their help

Key Scene: The first meeting where he explains the village's troubles

Secret: He knows that the old Imperial bridge was the site of a broken promise – a tax collector swore an oath on his child's life and then defaulted. The child vanished. Thorne still leaves milk on the bridge steps every full moon.

Stats: Presence 2, Spirit 3, Command 2, Lore 1

Villain Motivations: Garrick Ursillo

Primary Motivations (choose one or roll d4):

- **The Abandoned Soldier:** Garrick was once a decorated Vhasian soldier, discharged without pension after losing an arm in service. He turned to banditry to survive and now targets villages under the protection of the nobles who betrayed him. His brand is his shame.
- **The Debt Slave:** Garrick is being coerced by a Silkstrand crime lord (perhaps connected to a PC's backstory) to extract a massive debt from Millhaven. His cruelty is born of desperation.
- **The Ideologue:** Garrick genuinely believes the strong should rule the weak. He sees his "protection" as a natural order and views the villagers' defiance as a violation of the rightful way of things.
- **The Cursed:** Garrick broke an oath on the old Imperial bridge years ago. The Hollow has been following him ever since, and he lashes out because he is afraid. He does not know that the Hollow is not after him – it is after the oath he broke, and it will not stop until the promise is fulfilled or forgotten.

Secondary Traits:

- **Code of Honour:** He never harms children and always keeps his word (unless the word was given under duress).
- **Sentimental:** He carries a tattered locket with a portrait of a lost loved one. If the PCs return it to him after he drops it in battle, he may surrender.
- **Intellectually Curious:** He has a surprising respect for learning and might spare Kestra if she impresses him with her knowledge.

GM Application: Weave the chosen motivation into the story. For example, if using "The Abandoned Soldier," the PCs might find an old Acasian military insignia on a bandit, leading to a revelation that reframes the conflict.

Garrick Ursillo - Bandit Leader

Role: Cruel leader of the Ursillo Gang

Motivation: Power, control, and revenge (see above)

Personality: Ruthless, cunning, with a personal code of honour

Relationship to PCs: Immediate enemy who becomes obsessed with destroying them

Key Scene: The confrontation where he threatens the village

Stats: Body 4, Melee 4, Spirit 3, Command 2

Mira the Baker - Village Representative

Role: Spokesperson for the villagers

Motivation: Feed her family and keep the community together

Personality: Practical, caring, with hidden strength

Relationship to PCs: First villager to trust them, becomes a key ally

Key Scene: The scene where she offers the PCs a place to stay

Secret: Her grandmother was the last person to see the tax collector before he vanished. She knows where the broken promise was sworn, and she fears the Hollow every night.

Stats: Presence 2, Spirit 2, Sway 2, Survival 1

Tom the Smith - Village Defender

Role: Local blacksmith who helps with defence

Motivation: Protect his forge and the tools that feed his family

Personality: Gruff exterior, kind heart, practical fighter

Relationship to PCs: Respectful once they prove themselves

Key Scene: Training the villagers to fight

Stats: Body 3, Melee 2, Craft 2, Command 1

15 Optional Complications

15.1 Adding Depth

If your group wants more complexity, you can add these elements:

Political Intrigue: The Baroness's Gambit

For a more complex game, introduce **Baroness Valerius**, a local noble whose lands border Millhaven.

Her Motive: She wants to annex Millhaven for its fertile land but cannot do so openly. She has been secretly undermining the village, including *sabotaging their requests for aid* and *encouraging the Ursillo* (via intermediaries) to soften them up.

How it Unfolds:

- **Clue:** In Session 1, a bandit carries a coin from the Baroness's mint.
- **Development:** In Session 2, a "helpful" envoy from the Baroness arrives, offering protection in exchange for swearing fealty – a blatant power grab.
- **Confrontation:** In Session 3, if the PCs are winning, the Baroness might send her own troops under the pretext of "restoring order," aiming to claim the victory and the village.

New Mechanics:

- **The Baroness's Scheme Timer (6):** Tracks her progress toward annexing the village. It advances if the PCs trust her envoy or are weakened by the Ursillo.
- **New Asset:** *Evidence of Conspiracy (Minor)*: If the PCs uncover proof of her dealings with the Ursillo, they can use it to discredit her.

Supernatural Elements:

- The Ursillo are using cursed weapons that drain the life force of those they wound (each hit on a PC gives the GM 1 SB).
- Ancient spirits awakened by the violence demand tribute from both sides. The PCs may need to perform a ritual at the old Imperial bridge to appease them.
- One of the PCs discovers they have a mystical connection to the sacred grove near Millhaven. The grove is a threshold where the Hollow's attention is thin.
- Strange dreams plague the villagers, showing glimpses of possible futures. The PCs can use these dreams to gain +1 die on a future roll, but the GM gains 1 SB (the Hollow is watching).

Personal Stakes:

- A PC's family member is revealed to be living in Millhaven – perhaps a sibling who fled Silkstrand years ago.
- The Ursillo leader knows one of the PCs personally from their Silkstrand days. He may try to turn the other exiles against them.
- Villagers remind PCs of people from their past, creating emotional connections and difficult choices.
- A child in the village shares a name with someone important to a PC. When the child is endangered, the bond becomes personal.

15.2 Scaling the Challenge

For Experienced Players:

- Increase timer sizes by 2 segments each
- Add more Ursillo bandits to encounters (Cap 3-4 enemies)
- Introduce additional factions with competing interests (the Baroness, a wandering hedge-witch, a Ykrul scout)
- Garrick gains elite lieutenant followers (Cap 2-3 each)

For New Players:

- Decrease timer sizes by 2 segments each
- Provide more obvious clues and hints
- Reduce the number of Ursillo in combat encounters
- Garrick starts with fewer hit points and capabilities
- Offer more opportunities for assistance from villagers

For Larger Groups (5-6 players):

- Add 2-3 additional villagers as Cap 1 followers
- Introduce a second Ursillo lieutenant as a recurring threat
- Expand the scope to include neighbouring villages needing aid
- Add a subplot involving refugees fleeing Ursillo violence

16 Resolution and Continuation

16.1 Successful Defence

If the PCs successfully defend Millhaven:

- **Immediate Rewards:**
 - Permanent Assets reflecting their heroism (Village Militia, Elder's Trust, etc.)
 - 10-12 XP for each player
 - Respect and gratitude from the villagers
 - Choice of honorary titles or positions in the community (e.g., "Warden of the North Field," "Keeper of the Old Bridge")
- **Long-term Benefits:**
 - Millhaven becomes a safe base of operations
 - Villagers provide information and resources
 - Other communities seek their help
 - Regional reputation begins to grow
- **Story Hooks:**
 - Other villages face similar threats
 - Ursillo remnants seek revenge
 - Political forces take notice of the PCs (the Baroness may send an envoy)
 - The Hollow's attention remains – the Curse is not cured, only deferred
 - Ancient spirits demand continued service at the grove or bridge

16.2 The Road Ahead (Seeds for the Next Adventure)

If the party successfully defended Millhaven, they may hear new rumours as they recover:

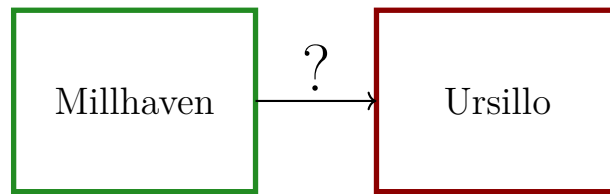
Continuing the Journey

- **Tema's Offer:** A Vilihari merchant named Tema arrives in Millhaven with a caravan of grain. She is impressed by the party's courage and offers them honest work – escorting a cargo to a monastery beyond the Valvano Ford. (Leads directly into *Beyond Millhaven*.)
- **The Bronze Gate:** A wounded soldier speaks of a mountain pass called the Bronze Gate, where a cursed seal has been unearthed. He mutters about a Prefect Marcellus and a thief called Quick Lena. (Seeds *The Bronze Gate*.)
- **Sarnai's Name:** A Ykrul trader mentions that Khatun Sarnai is looking for outsiders who can negotiate without drawing a blade. (Another hook to *Beyond Millhaven*.)
- **The Hollow's Whisper:** A child in the village claims to have heard a voice from the old bridge, asking for a name. The voice was familiar. The child cannot remember whose.

(A lingering thread for future Curse-related adventures.)

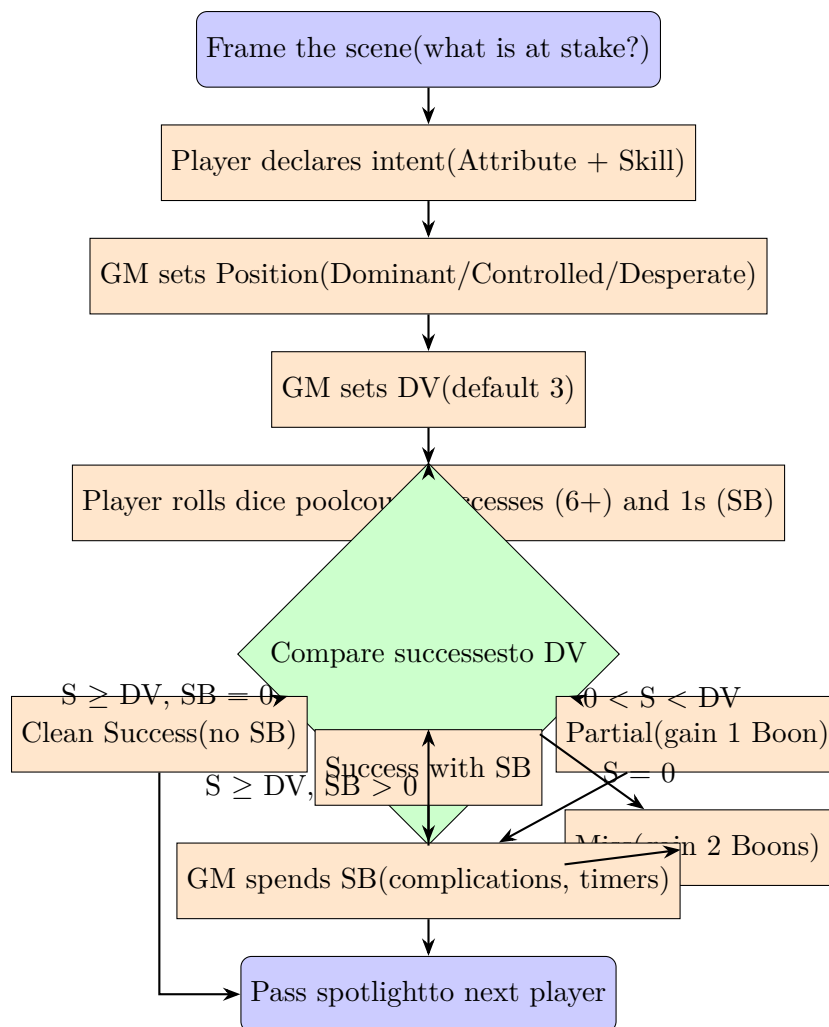
The road does not end here. The choices you made in Millhaven will echo in the valleys beyond.

“The Traveler does not promise a safe journey – only a true one.”



The choice is yours. Will you stand and fight, or will you fall back and regroup?

A Running Your First Game Flowchart



B Whispers on the Road: An Introduction to Magic

B.1 A Stranger at the Hearth

During their stay in Millhaven – perhaps after the first encounter with Garrick's men or while resting between patrols – the PCs notice a hooded figure who keeps to the shadows of the village's only tavern. Their accent is refined, their hands stained with ink, and their left eye holds a faint silver glint. They call themselves **Mareth**, once a scholar of Thepyrgos, now an exile walking the same broken roads as the party.

"I was like you – cast out, searching for a place where my skills were worth more than the price on my head. The road teaches, if you let it. I can show you the first steps into power that does not require a guild or a patron's blessing. But understand: every gift I offer comes with a thread of obligation. The road remembers every bargain."

Mareth is a disgraced **Runekeeper of the Traveler**, expelled from the City of a Thousand Stairs for unlocking forbidden way-routes. They now wander, offering basic instruction in three magical traditions to those who remind them of their former students. They do not teach high magic – only the **low rites** and foundational practices. Enough to test the waters, enough to survive.

B.2 Patron of the Ways: The Traveler

The Traveler is the eternal guide of roads, thresholds, and journeys – the presence that watches from every crossroads and listens at every waymark. Among the Fhara caravans and Kuvani traders along the Way of Silk, the Traveler is honoured with small offerings and whispered prayers before any significant trek.

Those who bond with the Traveler gain subtle powers over movement, paths, and safe passage. Its low rites are forgiving, rarely causing dangerous backlash, making it ideal for beginners.

Low Rites of the Traveler (Basic)

Road-Sense (Low Rite)

Cost: 1 action, mark +1 Obligation.

Effect: For the rest of the scene, you gain +1 die on Navigation, Survival, or Escape rolls. You unerringly sense the safest route within Near range.

Push (optional): Mark +1 Fatigue to extend the bonus to a second ally.

Traveler's Boon (Low Rite)

Cost: 1 action, mark +1 Obligation.

Effect: You or a touched ally ignores one level of difficult terrain or bureaucratic delay for the scene. Gain +1 Effect on travel or escape checks.

Push: Mark 1 Story Beat (Diamonds) to extend the boon to a second ally.

Waymark (Low Rite)

Cost: 1 action, mark +1 Obligation.

Effect: Chalk a small sigil on a door, path, or threshold. For the rest of the session, you

and allies who follow the marked route treat the first obstacle as one Position step safer (e.g., Desperate → Controlled).

Push: Mark +1 Obligation to make the mark last until the next dawn.

Bridge Between (Low Rite)

Cost: 1 action, mark +1 Obligation.

Effect: Relocate a willing ally or small object from Near to Far range (line of sight required). Unwilling targets may resist with Body+Resolve (DV 3).

Push: Mark 1 Story Beat (Clubs) to carry an additional ally.

B.3 Obligation and the Traveler's Ledger

When you invoke a Rite, mark +1 **Obligation** to the Traveler. Your **Obligation Capacity** equals your **Spirit + Presence**. If your total Obligation exceeds your Capacity, each excess segment causes 1 Fatigue (exhaustion, distraction, the road demanding a toll). You may reduce Obligation by performing a service for the Traveler (e.g., guiding lost travellers, marking a new waypoint, or making an offering at a crossroads) during downtime.

B.4 Three Paths, One Mentor

Mareth offers to teach the basics of **three magical traditions**. Each requires a different focus, but all start with the same low rites of the Traveler. A character may learn only one of these paths during the adventure, but the knowledge can be expanded later.

B.4.1 Runekeeper (The Traveler's Ledger)

You carve the Traveler's sigils into a small token – a brass coin, a smooth stone, or a leather wristband. Each rite is a structured invocation, reliable and swift.

Requirements: Obtain a *Codex* (a small notebook of way-sigils, 2 XP) and a *Familiar* (the token itself, 2 XP). Mareth provides these for free as part of the lesson.

Mechanics: You may invoke any Traveler low rite as 1 action, marking +1 Obligation. You do not need to roll unless the rite is resisted. Your Patron's Gift (Imbuement) allows you to spend 1 action to bless a held item with +1 Melee and +1 Thematic (e.g., Navigation or Survival) for one scene, marking +1 Obligation.

B.4.2 Cantor (Songs of the Open Road)

You learn to hum the Traveler's melodies – short verses that ease travel and confound pursuers.

Requirements: Performance 2+, Lore 1+. Mareth teaches you three *low songs*: *Road-Sense*, *Traveler's Boon*, and *Waymark*.

Mechanics: Each song requires a **Performance + Lore** roll (DV 3) and takes 1 action. On success, the effect lasts for the scene. On a failure, you gain 1 Fatigue but may try again later. You do not mark Obligation; instead, mark +1 on a **Corruption Timer** (size = your Spirit) when you *Push* a song (see below). When the timer fills, you gain a minor burden from the Traveler (e.g., you must always take the longer road, or you cannot refuse a request for directions).

Push: Resolve the song immediately (instead of waiting a turn) and mark +1 Corruption segment.

B.4.3 Invoker (The Traveler's Symbol)

You carry a small brass compass that never points north – it points to the nearest safe threshold. You do not bond with the Traveler; you borrow grace through ritual.

Requirements: Obtain a *Patron's Symbol* (the compass, 4 XP). Mareth provides a simple one.

Mechanics: Perform any Traveler low rite as a **ritual** (takes 1 round per DV, minimum 2 rounds). When you display the compass openly, reduce the rite's DV by 1 (min 1) and reduce Obligation cost by 1 (min 0). Without the symbol, the rite takes +1 round and marks +1 extra Obligation.

Crack the Seal: Once per session, you may resolve a rite instantly by setting the compass to *Compromised* (it ticks erratically) and marking +2 Obligation. Restore the compass during downtime with a Craft or Arcana test (DV 3).

B.5 Threadweaving: Freeform Magic (Optional)

For those who prefer improvisation over structured rites, Mareth also teaches a raw, tag-based form of magic called **threadweaving**. This is the same system used by free casters in the wider world.

“The road is made of threads – paths taken, paths refused, paths that might have been. A clever hand can snip a thread here, knot one there, and change the journey without walking a single step.”

Casting Threadweave: Choose a verb and one or more **tags** from the table below. The GM sets a Difficulty Value (DV) equal to $1 + \text{number of tags}$ (tags marked with * add +2 DV instead). Roll **Wits + Arcana**. On a success, the effect manifests. On a miss, the GM may apply backlash (Fatigue, a Story Beat, or a minor complication).

Tag	Meaning
subtle	Invisible, silent, hard to detect
flashy	Obvious, loud, attracts attention
helpful	Assists an ally (e.g., +1 die on next roll)
entangling	Restrains or slows a target
knowing	Reveals information or senses hidden things
leap*	Short-range teleport (Near distance)
veil*	Conceal a person or object from sight

Example: *“I tug the thread of the guard's attention – subtle, knowing.”* DV = $1 + 2 = 3$. On success, the guard looks away for a moment.

This freeform magic does not generate Obligation, but each use risks Fatigue or narrative twists at the GM's discretion. It is ideal for players who want occasional magical flair without committing to a full path.

B.6 Lore of the Traveler (GM Eyes Only)

The Traveler is one of the thirty-five Patrons detailed in the *Fate's Edge Core Rulebook*. Its domain is *ways and journeys* – every path, threshold, and choice between two roads. The Traveler does not demand worship, only that travellers respect the road and keep their bargains.

Sigil: A spiral that ends in a fork – the choice that defines the journey.

Whispered in Taverns: *“One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway. But break your word to the way, and the way will break you.”*

Corruption of the Traveler (summarized): As a character deepens their bond, they become restless, unable to stay in one place for long, and eventually risk becoming a permanent wanderer, unable to settle anywhere.

Mareth's exile stems from their attempt to map a hidden *way-between* – a path that connects two points without crossing the intervening space. The Thepyrgos Synod declared it heresy. The Traveler accepted the discovery but demanded a price: Mareth can never return to the city. They now wander, teaching the basics to those who, like them, have lost their home.

B.7 Continuing the Journey

This appendix offers a gentle first step into the magic of Fate's Edge. The full rules – including higher-tier rites, detailed Patron obligations, backlash, and the Cantor's Corruption mechanics – await in the core rulebook. For now, let the road be your teacher, and may every crossroads offer a choice worth making.

“The Traveler does not promise a safe journey – only a true one.”

I was there when the guildhouse burned. I pulled Kestra from the canal. She does not remember me. The living forget. The dead do not.